

Madrid Noir

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ABSTRACT

We have created a 45 minute Virtual Reality Narrative with moments of interaction to engage the viewer. The narrative concerns a woman named Lola, and follows her memories of a summer spent with her estranged uncle in Madrid in 1930. Madrid Noir aims to explore the possibilities for narrative storytelling using the medium of Virtual Reality.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Applied computing → Media arts.

KEYWORDS

virtual reality, interaction, narrative design

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1 AIMS

Madrid Noir was created with the vision of building a narrative story in Virtual Reality that would take full advantage of the capabilities of the medium. As well as telling an animated story, the viewer would be able to interact with the characters and environments to build a sense of immersion in the world of Madrid Noir. We wanted to create an experience with a focus on the level of quality of the animation. The aim was to evoke a feeling similar cinematic feature animation within the constraints of mobile VR hardware.

2 STORY SUMMARY

After her estranged uncle is declared dead, a disenchanted young woman arrives in Madrid to empty the apartment that he left behind. Lola is soon compelled to dig into her memories, where she'll pick up her uncle's shadowy trail and attempt to piece together the puzzles of the past. Staged as an awe inspiring theatre production, this charming mystery unfolds across a city that lives in the night, a Madrid now lost to time.

3 STORY STRUCTURE

Working in VR means we're able to use changes in the perspective of the viewer to reinforce the narrative direction, and build empathy with Lola. Our story takes place between two different time periods - the 1930s and the 1950s. During the 1950s, the viewer is taking part in events 1st person, directly interacting with Lola and helping her solve the mystery. When we are taken back into Lola's memories of the 1930s, we see events predominantly in the 3rd person, giving a dream-like quality to the animation.

We wanted to make sure that watching Madrid Noir comes as a seamless experience. The narrative is designed to flow in combination with interactive moments with the aim of achieving a rhythm that keeps the viewer engaged with the action, drawing them deeper into the world that we've created. It was key, in our minds to make sure that the viewer is never stuck trying to work out what they need to do. The more that the viewer feels that they can intuitively explore their surroundings while progressing the story, the smoother the experience is going to be for them.

4 AESTHETIC

Madrid Noir is envisioned as if it were a theatre set unconstrained by the physical limits of the real world. We combine this staging with a film-Noir influenced aesthetic to create a stylised re-imagining of 1930s Madrid. This set up gives us a framework to tell the story of Madrid Noir effectively in VR, James was able to direct the attention of the viewer using classic theatrical devices such as spotlights and changes in the set.

Our bespoke material was created to show a painterly style, whilst also performing well enough to work within the constraints of mobile hardware. This material also takes advantage of vertex animation to ensure efficient animation of assets without the use of conventional bone animation.

5 INTERACTIONS

The interactions in Madrid Noir are designed to add a sense of immersion for the viewer, but also to progress the storyline and maintain the pacing of the narrative. Our number one consideration when thinking about the interactive elements was to never present the viewer with a situation where they would be unsure of what to do next, or searching around for something that would hold up the flow of the experience. The interactions range from searching for clues in Manolo's office, trying to find him with a torch, developing photos, and interacting directly with Lola by passing objects to her.

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